

Muriel's



Pirate Picnic

This isn't just a story. There's a puzzle too. Partway through you will meet Pirate Jake. There are several different pictures of him. Make sure you look at the pictures very carefully, because not all of them are quite the same. See if you can spot the differences.



Today was Thursday and Muriel had just finished breakfast. She was wearing her **red** dress. She was looking out the window, and she was sad. ‘Oh dear!’ she said. ‘I really wanted to go out and play, but it’s raining again.’

Daddy checked the weather forecast on his phone. ‘Hmm,’ he said. ‘It’s going to be like this all day I’m afraid.’

He paused for a moment. ‘I know,’ he said, ‘we’ll just have to play some indoor games instead.’

‘That’s a good idea,’ said Mummy. ‘And we’ll make a cake. A cake is always good to cheer you up when it’s raining.’

Muriel thought about that. It had been raining every day for the last week. That sounded like an awful lot of cake. You might get a tummy ache if you ate all that. But on the other hand, Mummy was right – it did sound like fun.

Daddy got a pack of cards and turned on the light in the corner to make things look cosier, and they all snuggled down in front of the fire. They played snap seven times, and Muriel won seven times, and Mummy and Daddy didn’t.

And all of a sudden, it was ten o’clock.

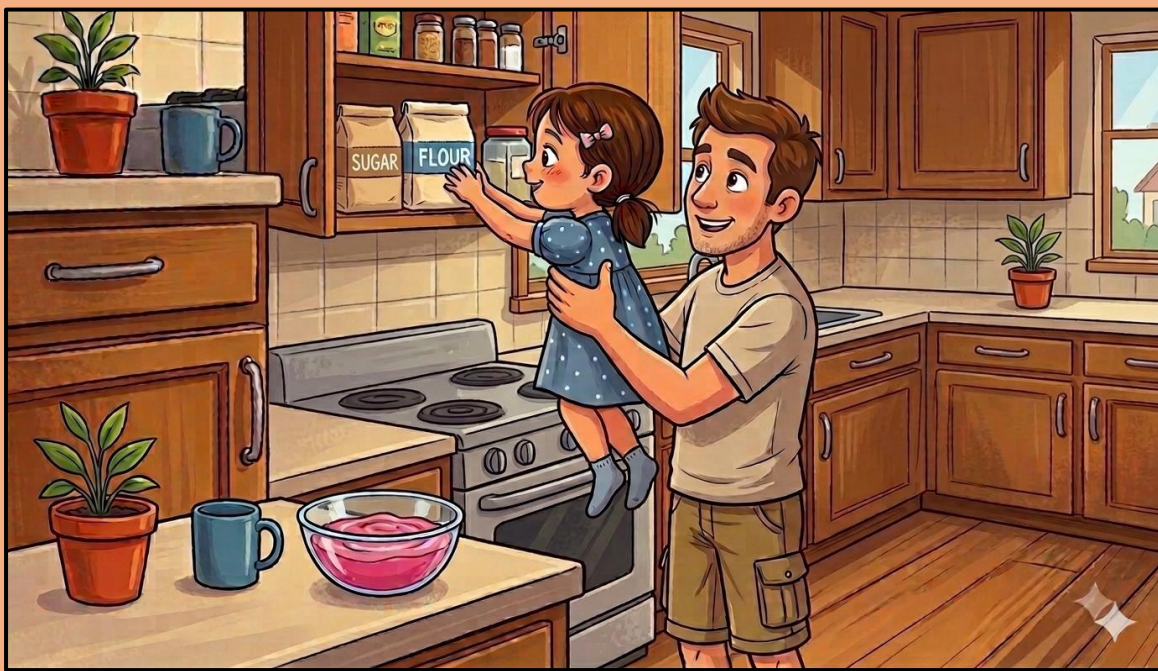
‘Right,’ said Mummy. ‘Cake time. What sort shall we make?’

Muriel tried to imagine all her favourite kinds of cake. ‘Sponge cake,’ she said. ‘Sponge cake with jam filling and pink icing.’

‘Sounds good,’ said Daddy, going with Mummy and Muriel to the kitchen. ‘So, what are we going to need?’

‘Flour,’ said Muriel.

Daddy lifted her up so she could reach the top cupboard. She took the bag of flour and passed it down to Mummy.



‘And sugar,’ said Muriel. Daddy lifted her up again and she passed down a bag of sugar.

‘Actually,’ she said, ‘you also need another kind of sugar for the icing.’ She passed down some more sugar in a box.

‘And we’ll need two bowls – one for the cake and one for the icing. But they’re under the kitchen side, so I can reach those.’

‘Don’t forget the eggs,’ said Daddy. Muriel reached up on to the work surface and carefully took some eggs from the egg basket and gave them to Mummy.

‘And you’ll need some butter,’ said Daddy.

‘Not butter, silly,’ said Muriel, ‘margarine. Granny says that cakes work a lot better with margarine.’ And she went to the fridge and got out the margarine.

‘OK,’ said Daddy to Mummy, ‘now we have to decide who does what. Heads you make the cake and Muriel and I will make the icing. Tails *I* make the cake and *you* do the icing.’

He tossed a coin. It was heads, but Mummy asked if Muriel could help her first because she needed a helper to weigh out the flour and sugar and margarine. So they got out the scales and turned them on, and put a bowl on top, and Muriel carefully poured out the flour until the scales said 225, and then did the same with the sugar and the margarine.

Then she went back to Daddy. ‘I don’t often make icing,’ he said. ‘Do you know what to do?’

‘Of course,’ said Muriel. ‘You take some icing sugar in a bowl and then you pour some water in, and you stir it around. I’ll show you.’

So she did. Stirring it was quite difficult because it went all gloopy, and by the time Muriel had finished her arm ached a bit, but it was all ready. All it needed was a cake to put it on.

‘I can’t help feeling there’s something missing,’ said Daddy. ‘But I can’t think what it is.’

‘Pink stuff!’ Muriel said. ‘We forgot the pink stuff. You can’t have pink icing without that.’

So Daddy lifted her up again and she moved things around in the cupboard until she found a small bottle labelled ‘Pink stuff’, and she got it down, and they put two drops into the icing and stirred it around and it went a lovely pink colour.



‘Well,’ said Daddy, ‘that certainly *looks* good. But the question is, does it *taste* good too? And we can’t be certain about that unless we try it, I don’t think.’

So he got two teaspoons, and he and Muriel each took a spoonful. ‘Mmm,’ said Muriel. ‘Delicious.’

In the meantime Mummy had finished making the cake mixture.

‘Same thing with the cake mixture I should think,’ said Daddy. ‘It definitely *looks* like cake mixture, but we probably ought to check it. What we need is an expert cake taster. Now who can we get to do that?’

He looked at Mummy. ‘I know,’ they said to each other. ‘Perhaps Muriel could help.’

So Muriel took her spoon. And she took a spoonful in her mouth. And she made kind of ‘Yum’ noises.

‘So,’ said Daddy, ‘is it all right?’

Muriel made some more ‘Yum’ noises, but she couldn’t talk properly because her mouth was full of cake mixture.

Daddy looked at Mummy. ‘I think that probably means it’s ok. And while it’s cooking, I think perhaps Muriel should scrape out anything which is left in the bowl.’

Mummy put the mixture into two cake tins, and gave the empty bowl to Muriel so she could eat the bits which were left, and then Daddy took all the bowls and spoons and things and washed up.

Muriel stood in front of the oven and watched through the glass door. At first the cake mixture was a bit flat and sad and white looking. And then it wasn't quite so flat or sad and it started looking a bit less white. And after what seemed a *very* long time, it was big and happy and golden brown and ready to come out.



Mummy took it out, and she took the cake out of the tins and spread jam on top of one of the pieces, and then put the other piece on top of that. And when it had cooled down a bit, Daddy and Muriel spread the icing all over it, and Daddy got two cherries and Muriel drew a smiley face in the icing and put the cherries on for eyes, and they all agreed it was the best-looking cake they had ever seen. Apart from granny's cakes, of course, because everyone knows that grannies always do make the best cakes, and specially Muriel's granny.

'Right,' said Mummy. 'Time for some more games I think. And then it will be time for lunch. Do you know what you'd like?'

Muriel thought. 'Chips,' she said. 'Chips, and then cake for afters.'

'Sounds like my kind of lunch,' said Daddy.

So they played snap again for a while. They played five times, and Muriel won five times, and Mummy and Daddy didn't. And then it was lunchtime, and everyone agreed that they were the best chips and the best cake they'd ever had.

And in the afternoon, they all played snakes and ladders, and Muriel went up all the ladders, and Mummy and Daddy went down all the snakes, and so Muriel won seven times and Mummy and Daddy didn't.

And then it was tea and bed.





Today was Friday and Muriel had just finished breakfast. She was wearing her **green** dress.

She was looking out the window and she was sad. ‘Oh dear!’ she said. ‘I really wanted to go out and play, but it’s raining again.’

Daddy checked the weather forecast on his phone. ‘Hmm,’ he said. ‘It’s going to be like this all day I’m afraid.’

He paused for a moment. ‘I know,’ he said, ‘we’ll just have to play some indoor games.’

‘That’s a good idea,’ said Mummy. ‘And we’ll make some biscuits. Biscuits are always good to cheer you up when it’s raining.’

Muriel thought about that. It had been raining every day for the last week. That sounded like an awful lot of biscuits. You might get a tummy ache if you ate all those. But on the other hand, Mummy was right – it did sound like fun.

Daddy got the box of games and turned on the light in the corner to make things look cosier, and they all snuggled down in front of the fire. They played tiddleywinks seven times, and Muriel won seven times, and Mummy and Daddy didn’t.

And all of a sudden, it was ten o’clock.

‘Right,’ said Mummy. ‘Biscuit time. What sort shall we make?’

Muriel knew the answer to that straight away. ‘Chocolate chip cookies,’ she said.

‘Mmm,’ said Daddy, going with Mummy and Muriel to the kitchen. ‘My favourites. So, what are we going to need?’

‘A lot of the same things as yesterday,’ said Muriel, so Daddy helped her get them all down from the cupboards.

‘Oh yes, and chocolate chips of course.’

Daddy lifted her up again. She looked at the front of the shelf. She looked at the sides of the shelf. She moved all the things around and looked at the back of the shelf.

‘Humph,’ she said. ‘No chocolate chips.’

‘Oh dear,’ said Daddy. ‘We’ll just have to go to the shops.’

He turned to Mummy. ‘I’ll toss you for it. Heads you go out to the shops in the pouring rain and get soaking wet while I stay here with Muriel and make the cookie dough. Tails, Muriel and I get wet while *you* do the cooking.’

He tossed a coin. It was tails.

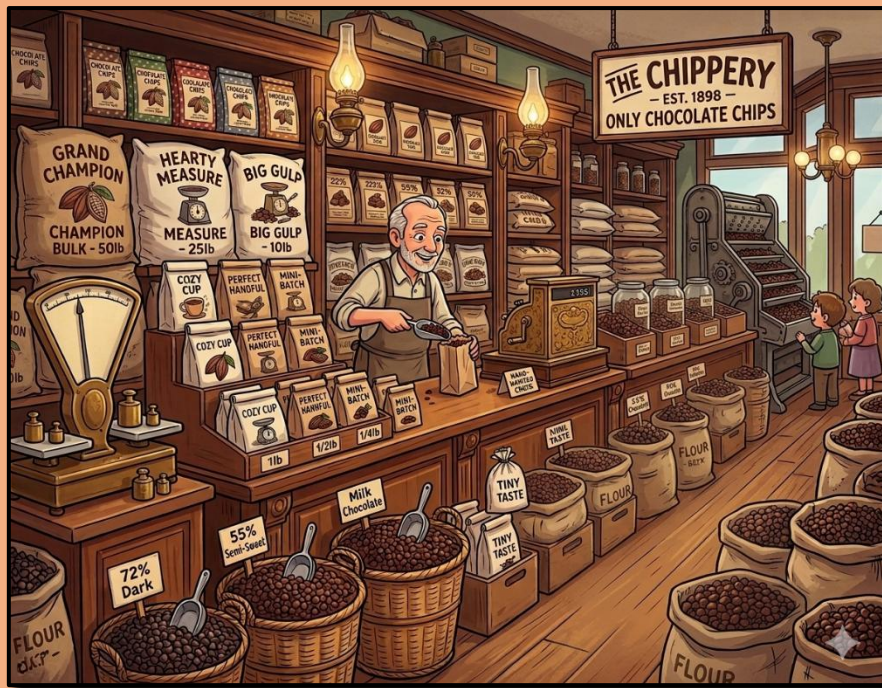
Daddy turned to Muriel. ‘Looks like we’re going to have to go and get the chocolate chips,’ he said.

Daddy put on his big green raincoat and his big black boots and his hat. Muriel put on her yellow raincoat and her red boots and her hat and they set off.



‘I know,’ Daddy said. ‘Let’s have a splashing-in-the-puddles competition. I’ll go first, and then you can try. The one who makes the biggest splash is the winner.’

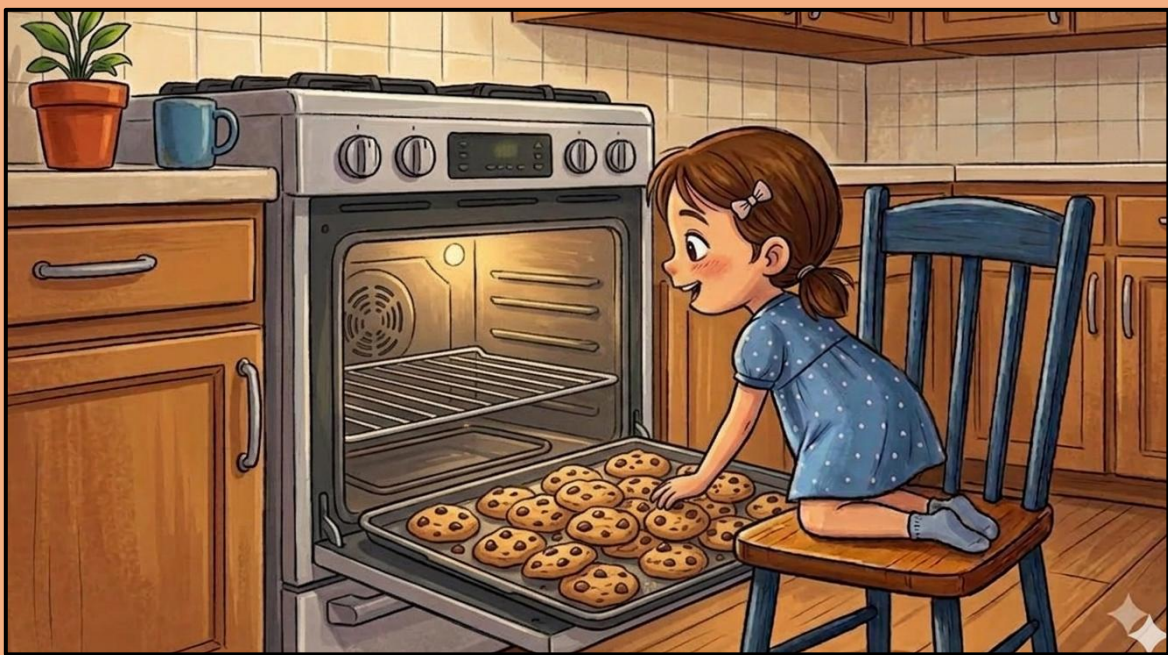
He found a big puddle and jumped in it. But it wasn’t a very good jump, because Daddy was a grown up, and grown ups aren’t very good at jumping in puddles. In fact it was rather a polite kind of jump. But even so, the splash came up almost as high as the top of his boots. Then Muriel found a puddle and jumped in it very hard indeed, and made a splash half way up her tummy, which meant she was winning. And so they carried on taking it in turns until they got to the chocolate chip shop.



They went into the shop and Muriel chose the biggest bag of chocolate chips she could find, and they stood there at the checkout with water dripping off them while Daddy paid. And then they carried on with the competition all the way home, and when they got back they decided it was a draw.

Muriel took the chocolate chips and gave them to Mummy, and Mummy stirred them into the cookie mixture and divided it up into cookie-sized chunks and put them on a tray in the oven.

Muriel stood in front of the oven and watched through the glass door. But the cookies didn't get bigger like the cake had done, so it was a bit boring. It was a bit boring until Mummy took them out, that is, and they all lay on their tray looking very cookie-ish, and very much as though they wanted to be eaten. Then it wasn't boring at all.



Daddy reached out to take one, but Mummy looked very stern. ‘No,’ she said, ‘we need to let them cool down first. We’ll play some more games while we’re waiting, and then we’ll have some lunch. What would you like for lunch, by the way?’

Daddy looked at Muriel. ‘What do you think?’ he asked. ‘Chips and cookies?’

‘Sounds good to me,’ said Muriel.

So they played Happy Families seven times, and Muriel won seven times, and Mummy and Daddy didn’t; and then it was lunchtime, and everyone agreed that they were the best chips and the best chocolate chip cookies they’d ever had.

And in the afternoon, Daddy got down lots of jars and tins and packets from the kitchen cupboard, and Muriel set up a pretend shop, and Mummy and Daddy came and bought lots of things from her shop, which was really good fun.

And then it was tea and bed.





Today was Saturday and Muriel had just finished breakfast. She was wearing her **blue** dress.

She was looking out the window. And guess what! It was sunny !!! She was very happy.

Mummy came and stood beside her to look out of the window.

‘Can I go outside and play today?’ asked Muriel.

‘Hmm,’ said Mummy, ‘I think we should all do something special because it’s sunny.’

Muriel was very excited. She knew what ‘something special’ meant, because she had something none of her friends had. She had her very own yacht! It was called Nimrod, and it was very white and shiny, and it could go through the water ever so fast. And whenever Mummy said ‘something special’ it meant they were going to have an adventure in the yacht.

‘Yes,’ Mummy said. ‘I think we should make a picnic and go for a trip in Nimrod. I think we should go and find a nice sandy beach where we can have lunch, and we can go swimming and paddling and look in rock pools and make sandcastles.’

‘Ooh yessssss !!!’ said Muriel, and she rushed upstairs to change into her swimming costume under her dress, and to fetch her sun hat and her bucket and spade. Meantime, Mummy and Daddy cut sandwiches and put apples and crisps and the left-over cake and cookies into plastic boxes and then put the whole lot into a picnic basket. And mummy got the sun tan cream and some big blankets to lie on, and the sun shade.

And ten minutes later, they were all in the car on the way to the place where Nimrod lived.

And thirty minutes after *that*, they were all aboard Nimrod, and they all had their life jackets on, and they were ready to go.

‘Cast off for’ard, Mr Mate,’ called Mummy.

‘Aye aye Cap’n,’ said Daddy, untying the pointy end of the boat. ‘For’ard cast off.’

‘Cast off aft, Miss Mate,’ called Mummy.

‘Aye aye Cap’n,’ said Muriel, untying the back of the boat. ‘Aft cast off.’

Mummy pulled the sail up, and Nimrod slid smoothly away down river and headed out to sea.



Nimrod headed out to sea ... and then stopped.

‘Oh dear,’ said Mummy. ‘The wind seems to have dropped. There’s only one thing for it. Daddy, I need you to stand just in front of the sail and blow very hard until we get there.’

‘Are you sure about this?’ asked Daddy doubtfully. ‘It’s just that I have a feeling it can’t work.’ But he stood by the sail anyway, and he blew very hard, and then he blew even harder, and then even harder still ... and nothing happened.



‘Is that the best you can do?’ asked Mummy.

‘Yes,’ panted Daddy, ‘it jolly well is. *And* I’m starting to feel dizzy.’

Suddenly there was a splash by the side of the boat and a dolphin stuck its nose out of the water and smiled at them.

‘I don’t know what *you’re* grinning at,’ said Daddy. ‘This is very hard work, you know.’

‘Two things,’ said the dolphin. ‘First, I’ve just been reading a book of granda’s fish jokes, and they’re *very* funny. And second, I’m smiling because you’re going so slowly. I could swim backwards with my eyes shut and go faster than that.’

Daddy looked very surprised. ‘I didn’t know dolphins were clever enough to talk,’ he said.

‘I didn’t know *people* were clever enough to talk,’ said the dolphin. ‘So that makes us even. But you’re wasting your breath, and you don’t seem to have very much to spare. Anyway, I only popped up to see if you need a hand.’

‘Not, now that I come to think of it, that I *have* any hands,’ he continued. ‘But I *can* help you. If you just throw me a rope and tell me where you want to go, I can pull you there. Or else you can just carry on going on and on about dolphins being able to smile and talk and you’ll still be here when it’s dark. So what is it to be?’

Mummy came over to the side of the boat with a rope and threw it to the dolphin. ‘That’s very kind of you,’ she said. ‘We’d like to go to the beach, please.’



‘My pleasure,’ said the dolphin. I can’t quite take you *all* the way in, or I’ll get stuck on the sand. But I can get you very close, and then you can use your little rowing boat after that.

So off they went, and the dolphin pulled them almost all the way, and then it jumped out of the water and waved goodbye to them with its tail, and swam off, still laughing.

Mummy dropped anchor, and Daddy got the pump out and started blowing the rowing boat up, when suddenly there was a brmming noise.

‘That’s funny,’ said Mummy. ‘If I didn’t know better, I’d say that was a hovercraft.’

The brmming noise carried on, and Mummy was quite right, because Mummy was *always* right about boats and things – a hovercraft came flying around the corner, and on the front of it was a man with an eye patch and a wooden leg and a parrot.



‘Boo!’ said the man very loudly.

No one jumped or anything.

The man looked a bit disappointed. ‘Boo!’ he said, even more loudly.

Still no one jumped.

‘Boo?’ he said.

‘Why do you keep on saying boo?’ asked Mummy.

‘It’s to scare you, of course,’ the man said.

‘You don’t think perhaps that’s a bit unkind?’ asked Mummy.

The pirate looked sad. ‘I’m very sorry,’ he said, ‘but I’m a pirate, you see, and if you’re a pirate you *have* to scare people. That’s the rules,’ he went on. ‘If you don’t scare people enough, they take your licence away and throw you out of the Pirates Mutual Society, and then you’re not allowed to be a

pirate, which means you don't have an honest job any more, and all you can do then is go and stack the shelves at Sainsbury's.



‘The trouble is,’ he explained, ‘that I’m not awfully *good* at being scary – I only got a C-minus for that part of the course. In fact’ – and he looked *very* sad – ‘I have to admit that actually I’m really not very good at all at being a pirate.’

‘Oh dear,’ said Mummy. ‘*I am* sorry. I can see that must be a bit difficult. But changing the subject for a moment, what’s with the hovercraft? I thought pirates were supposed to use sailing ships?’

‘Woodworm,’ said the pirate. ‘You’re right – really I *ought* to have a sailing ship, and I did used to have one. But they do have such awful problems with woodworm. I was in the middle of breakfast one day when the main topsail landed in my cornflakes *that* far from my head. Woodworm had eaten clean through the mast.

‘And of course there’s the wind too. I’d nearly caught up with a Spanish galleon once – got to within about 20m when the wind dropped. Absolute flat calm. No wind for a whole week. So I carried *on* being 20m away, and they all just laughed and poked their tongues out at me.

‘No – hovercraft are *much* more convenient. No woodworm, and they can always move so long as you remember to fill them up with petrol. Plus no one can do jokes about how many miles you do to the galleon, which is a relief – I don’t know how many times I’ve heard that one.

‘However, to get back to my reason for being here, I don’t suppose you’ve got any gold doubloons about you?’ he asked hopefully. ‘I could steal those instead, and that would still count towards my bad deeds for the week.’

‘Afraid not,’ said Daddy. ‘I’ve only got thirty seven pennies – but you’re welcome to them that if it would help?’

‘Ah,’ said the pirate, shaking his head sadly. ‘Probably not – I don’t think it would be enough.’

‘Tell me,’ said Mummy, ‘Have you ever, in fact, scared *anybody* or stolen *anything*?’

The pirate looked down at his feet and it seemed as though he was going to start crying. ‘Not really,’ he said. ‘I don’t really like scaring people or stealing things from them. In fact quite often I *give* people things if they look as though they don’t have enough. As I said, I’m really not a very good pirate. The thing is, I’ve never done anything else, and I do rather like dressing up and going around on my hovercraft.’

And he looked *so* sad that Muriel felt very sorry for him. So she had a very hard think about how to cheer him up. And then she had a very good idea.

‘I know,’ she said. ‘We’re going to have a picnic on the beach and play games. Why don’t you come with us? We’ve got plenty of chocolate chip cookies and cake and sandwiches. And then after lunch you could take a selfie of all of us together, and we could look scared, and you could show that to anyone who wanted to check up on what you’ve been doing.’

‘Well,’ said the pirate, ‘that *would* be awfully kind of you. It *is* kind of quiet on Saturdays, because the rest of my pirate crew have Saturdays off to go home and visit their mummies and daddies and wash their socks, which means I’m all on my own. And chocolate chip cookies are my absolute favourites. Or they are after cake and sandwiches. So if you *really* don’t mind, I’d like that very much indeed.’



‘In fact,’ he went on, much more cheerfully, ‘in that case you needn’t bother finishing blowing up your rowing boat – we can use my hovercraft to get to the beach. Just bring all the stuff over here and load her up.’

‘Oh, and by the way,’ he said, ‘the name’s Black Jake. But do call me just Black – all my friends do. Or actually,’ he admitted, ‘don’t call me Black. Black Jake is just my pirate name. Really I’m called Nigel, but it’s a bit difficult to be taken seriously as a pirate if you tell people that.’

‘Hmm,’ said Daddy. ‘I think you’re right. Nigel *doesn’t* really seem right if you’re a pirate. So perhaps we could call you Jake, if that’s ok. Anyway, we’re very pleased to meet you. I’m Daddy and this is Mummy.’

‘And I’m Muriel,’ said Muriel, shaking the pirate’s hand.

So Daddy and Muriel brought the picnic basket and Muriel’s bucket and spade, and a spare bucket and spade in case Jake needed one, and Mummy brought the picnic basket, and the towels and blankets for lying on, and the sun tan cream, and the pirate turned the hovercraft on again and they brmmed over the water to the beach.

The pirate parked the hovercraft at the top of the beach where it wouldn’t get washed away if the tide came in, and then they got all the things out of it, and Mummy laid the blankets out on the sand while Daddy unpacked the picnic basket and the toys.

The pirate stretched out on one of the blankets and gave a long and happy-sounding sigh. ‘Well,’ he said, ‘shiver me timbers and splice the mainbrace and avast behind.’

‘Wow,’ said Muriel, ‘I’ve never heard *those* words before. What do they mean?’

‘To be honest,’ said the pirate, ‘I’ve never had the faintest idea. But it’s something you *have* to say if you’re a pirate. I can tell you what it means at the moment, though. It means “I’m ever so glad I met you all, and you’re being really kind to me, and this is the nicest thing I’ve ever done, and it’s really nice just lying here and letting the sun warm me up.” Or that’s roughly what it means anyway.’

And he closed his eyes, and gave another contented sigh and fell asleep.



Seeing him nearly asleep, Muriel moved up close to Mummy and Daddy and whispered in their ears. ‘I don’t think Jake often gets treats, which is very sad. Why don’t we surprise him and give him *all* of the chocolate chip cookies? We can always just have a piece of cake ourselves, and it would be really nice if it helps to make him happy.’

Mummy and Daddy said that was a very kind thought. So they laid the cookies out on a blanket and then Muriel tapped the pirate gently on the shoulder to wake him up and said it was lunchtime and that they had a surprise for him, and she gave him a glass of lemonade and showed him the cookies.

‘Do you mean I can have one of those?’ asked the pirate, looking very excited.

‘No,’ said Daddy. ‘You can’t.’

The pirate looked surprised and a bit miserable.

‘No,’ said Muriel. ‘You can’t have *one*. You can have all of them!’

The pirate was so pleased that he actually burst into tears. But he didn’t stay that way for long, because soon he was tucking into the cookies and smiling a lot.



And after he’d finished the cookies, they all had sandwiches and cake.

‘Yummy,’ said the pirate. ‘That was absolutely delicious. What shall we do now?’

‘Football?’ said Daddy. ‘Would you like a game of football?’

‘Great!’ said the pirate. ‘First though, Muriel had a very good idea just now. Remember? She suggested we do a selfie of me pretending to be fierce and you pretending to be scared so I can show it to people who think I’m not being pirate-ish enough. Would that be ok?’

Everyone said yes, so they all got close together, and the pirate got his phone out.

‘Say “Cheese!”’ he said. ‘Or no, of course don’t do that. That won’t work at all. You need to look scared, not smiley.’

The pirate frowned very hard, and everyone else looked really scared, and he pressed the button and took the picture.



‘Thank you,’ he said, ‘that should do the job. Now,’ he went on, ‘what about that game of football. First one to five goals is the winner!’

So Daddy and the pirate started playing football, and they were both very good at it.



Muriel watched for a while. And then she and Mummy went and had a look at the crabs and fishes in the rock pools.



When they got back from the rock pool, Mummy said it would be good to have a little rest, and while they did that, the pirate told them lots of funny stories about being a pirate, and told them about the time he'd been to a desert island and had found a real treasure chest full of gold and diamonds.

Then they got out the buckets and spades and Daddy and the pirate made a special sand spiral that you could roll balls down, which was very clever, and Muriel had lots of goes with it.



Then it was Muriel's turn, and she took her bucket and spade and made the most amazing sandcastle.



‘Oh wow!’ said Mummy.

‘Oh wow!’ said Daddy.

‘Oh wow!’ said the pirate. ‘I think that ought to win a prize.’

By now it was starting to get late. ‘Let’s just have a last paddle,’ said Mummy, ‘and then perhaps we ought to be getting home.’ So she and Muriel went down to the edge of the water and paddled until their feet started getting cold.



Then they came back and dried their feet off, and put the picnic basket and all the blankets and things back into the hovercraft. The pirate pressed the button, and they brmmed back to Nimrod.

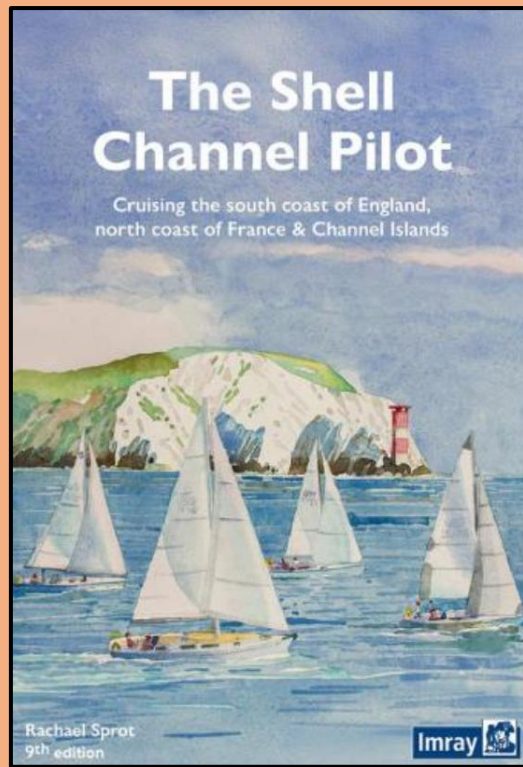
‘Well,’ said the pirate, ‘I think that’s the nicest day I’ve ever had.’ He reached into his pocket and pulled out a small piece of paper.

‘This is my business card,’ he said. ‘If you ever find yourself in need a pirate, just call.’



‘Thank you very much,’ said Daddy. ‘We’ll keep that in mind.’

‘By the way,’ said the pirate, ‘just before I go, could I recommend this book to you? Personally I couldn’t manage without it when I’m out and about. Make sure you get the 9th edition, though – it’s ever so much better than the 8th.’



Muriel was a bit sad, because their trip was over and she'd had such a nice time with the pirate. She went over to Mummy and whispered in her ear.

Mummy thought for a moment. 'Yes,' she said, 'I think that's a very good idea.' She turned to the pirate.

'Mr Pirate,' she said, 'or rather I mean Jake. We quite often have adventures in our boat. Would it be all right if I email you when we have our next adventure to see if you can come with us?'

'Oh,' said the pirate, 'yes *please*! That would be absolutely lovely. But I must go now, because Mrs Pirate is cooking toast this evening, and it will be ready. See you next time.'

And with that he turned the hovercraft round and brmmed away.

Mummy weighed the anchor, and Daddy did his best not to make the obvious joke, and the wind blew and Nimrod skimmed over the waves back to harbour, and Mummy steered her back alongside the jetty.

'Make her fast for'ard, Mr Mate,' called Mummy.

'Aye aye Cap'n,' said Daddy, tying up the pointy end of the boat. 'For'ard fast.'

'Make her fast aft, Miss Mate,' called Mummy.

'Aye aye Cap'n,' said Muriel, tying up the back of the boat. 'Aft fast.'

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'Oh,' said Muriel when they got home, 'That was an absolutely lovely day. I do hope we can do it again.' And she disappeared upstairs to get some toys.

Twenty minutes later, there was still no sign of her.

‘I suppose Muriel *is* all right,’ Daddy said. ‘Perhaps I’d better just go and check.’

So Daddy went up to see what had happened.

And here is what he found ...

